

The Complete Corporate Retreat Kit

Everything you need to run a leadership offsite: the room, the questions, the shape of the agenda, the checklist, the budget, the follow-through — and the one idea most agendas get backwards. All of it ready to edit.

1 Decide the outcome, then choose the room

2 A retreat breathes — inhale, exhale, inhale

3 Five questions to align with your sponsor

4 The 1.5-day agenda, mapped block by block

5 What goes in the blocks, by function

6 The venue & logistics checklist

7 Prep timeline & budget worksheet

8 What to do after — the 30 days that decide it

HOW TO USE THIS KIT

Read pages 2–3 first — they're the two ideas everything else is built on. Use pages 4–8 to actually run the offsite: the questions, the agenda, the checklist, the money. Use page 9 to make it stick after everyone's flown home.

2,000+

EVENTS PRODUCED

4.76/5

FROM 25,000+ REVIEWS

SINCE 2003

NATIONWIDE, ANY VENUE

Decide the outcome. Then choose the room.

The location is the format; the outcome is the function. Book the venue before the outcome is settled and you've capped what the offsite can do before anyone arrives — because availability drives the calendar, and the calendar drives the agenda.

DO THIS — THE LIVING ROOM

Nine executives, one rented house, no conference table. Couches, coffee, shoes off. Within an hour the deference is gone, because the furniture never established it. Right for new thinking, trust, anything that needs candor.

NOT THIS — THE BOARDROOM

Same nine people, their own boardroom, because it was free. Their brains know exactly what this room is for: status, execution, the deck. You will get their work selves. Wrong for anything creative or honest.

THE TELL

If you could run your agenda over a video call without losing anything, the location is doing no work — you've paid for a room instead of an instrument, and that room is usually the most expensive line on your budget page.

FINDING A ROOM THAT DOES THE WORK — FOUR PLACES TO LOOK

A rented house

Airbnb or VRBO, in the city the team's already in. Filter for 5+ bedrooms — not for the beds, for the rooms: a living room, a kitchen with seating, a deck or garden.

A university nearby

Campuses rent meeting halls, lecture rooms and lawns off-season for a fraction of a hotel — plus a walkable quad for every outdoor exhale.

A local camp or retreat center

Built for exactly this: a great room, breakouts, trails, a fire pit. Weekday rates are often cheaper than a downtown hotel block.

A state park lodge or nature center

Public, bookable, and the outdoor reset is built into the walk to the parking lot — often the cheapest square footage on this list.

THE HARD PART

Explaining a five-bedroom house — or a campground, or a lecture hall — to a procurement team whose vendor form only has a box for hotels. Hold the position anyway: the room is the cheapest lever you have on the whole budget, and it's the one everyone else skips.

Inhale, exhale. Then the next inhale.

Every session does one of two things. An **inhale** asks people to take something in and give something up — a hard truth, a decision, vulnerability. An **exhale** lets them put it down: food, movement, air, something to react to that isn't themselves.

A retreat is a sequence of these, and the sequence matters more than the content. Two inhales back to back and the room goes flat — not because people weren't ready, but because they were out of breath. An agenda of only exhales is a nice trip. Only inhales is an interrogation.

WHAT USUALLY GETS BUILT

↓ Trust session

↓ The hard topic

↓ Commitments

flat by 3pm

WHAT ACTUALLY WORKS

↓ Trust session

↑ Walk outside

↓ The hard topic

↑ Lunch, made together

↓ Commitments *still honest at 5*

TWO RULES THAT OVERRIDE THE CLOCK

Ninety minutes is the ceiling. After that, people stop being able to focus — come back to the topic in the next block instead of pushing through.

No phones in blocks, phones in breaks. Ban technology during the work and you owe people a real technology break to deal with their day — or you lose the room to anxiety instead of email.

THE HARD PART

Defending an empty twenty minutes to a room full of people who bill by the hour, while the agenda is already running late. Send them outside anyway — cut the exhale and you'll spend the next ninety minutes getting nothing.

Align with your sponsor in five questions.

The offsites that go sideways are the ones booked before anyone agreed what they were for. Ten minutes with your exec sponsor on these five questions saves you weeks — and gives you the language to defend every decision that follows.

1 Why this offsite, why now?

What's the real reason we're pulling people out of their week?

2 What does success look like the Monday after?

One or two things that should be true once everyone's back at their desk.

3 Who is in the room — and who isn't?

4 What's off-limits?

Topics, sacred cows — name them before someone finds them live.

5 What decision or commitment should the group leave with?

A retreat without a decision is a nice lunch. Name the outcome now.

RULE OF THUMB

The ratio that works is roughly $\frac{1}{3}$ content, $\frac{1}{3}$ conversation, $\frac{1}{3}$ connection. If your draft agenda is 90% presentations, you've built a conference, not a retreat.

NICE TO HAVE, NEVER MANDATORY

Send these five questions to your sponsor by email first — you'll get sharper answers than in a hallway conversation, and a paper trail when the scope creeps two weeks before the offsite.

The shape of a 1.5-day retreat.

Named by job and breath, not activity — fill it with whatever fits your outcome, using the key on the next page. Never end on logistics; always end on commitment.

TIME	BLOCK	BREATH	THE JOB OF THIS BLOCK
DAY 1 — ARRIVE AFTER LUNCH			
12–1:00	Arrival & lunch	↑ Exhale	Travel ends, the group assembles. No content — resist it.
1–1:30	The frame	↓ Inhale	Sponsor says why we're here, what's true Monday. Permission to be candid.
1:30–3:00	Block 1 · 90 min	↓ Inhale	First real work — a shared build or give-back to break hierarchy, then the debrief.
3–3:30	Reset	↑ Exhale	Move, eat, get outside. Phones allowed.
3:30–5:00	Block 2 · 90 min	↓ Inhale	Same topic, or the next one. Never a third block before dinner.
6:30	Dinner	↑ Exhale	No agenda, no seating chart, no toast.
DAY 2 — FINISH BY LUNCH			
8:45–9:00	Re-frame	↓ Inhale	Where we got to, what's left. Two minutes, not ten.
9–10:30	Block 3 · 90 min	↓ Inhale	The hard topic — put it here, the room is warmest and sharpest.
10:30–11:00	Reset	↑ Exhale	Outside if you can.
11–12	Commitments	↓ Inhale	Who owns what, by when. Written down and said out loud.
12–12:30	Close	↑ Exhale	Each person names one commitment. Then stop.

Read it back as a breath pattern. No two inhales without an exhale between them, nothing longer than ninety minutes, an outdoor break in every half-day, and the last working block is always commitments. Flat on paper, flat in the room.

What goes in the blocks.

Find your outcome and read across. The pattern holds even off this list: the environment does half the work, and the exhale is what makes the next inhale possible.

Brainstorm & new thinking

Room: anywhere they don't work — soft seating, no table between people.

Exhale: a walk, not more coffee.

1. Load the problem — constraints, data, no solving yet
2. Diverge — volume over quality, evaluation banned
3. Converge — kill most of it, name what gets tested

Worked when: the idea wasn't in anyone's head on arrival.

Trust, candor & safety

Room: domestic, not corporate — a kitchen, a living room. **Exhale:** food made together, not catered.

1. A shared build or give-back — hands busy, hierarchy off
2. The facilitated debrief — this is the session, not the activity
3. What we don't say to each other, and why

Worked when: someone says the thing they've carried for a year.

Strategy & alignment

Room: wall space and daylight, sober not novel. **Exhale:** short and functional — don't break the thread.

1. A shared picture of reality — argue facts before choices
2. The choice — 2–3 real options, tradeoffs said out loud
3. What we're saying no to — always after a break

Worked when: everyone states the strategy the same way, no deck.

Conflict — on the table

Room: warm, light on food, no easy exits. **Exhale:** separate them — a walk alone, never straight into lunch.

1. Each person says what's going wrong — timed, no replies yet
2. The replies — the facilitator holds the line here
3. What changes Monday — specific, owned, dated

Worked when: people say what they think, not what sounds right.

Annual planning

Room: long tables, a wall you can cover, good light. **Exhale:** a real break between looking back and looking forward.

1. Look back honestly — what we said, what we did, the gap
2. The few things that matter next year — fewer than feels safe
3. Sequencing and ownership — who, by when, what gets dropped

Worked when: the plan has fewer items than last year's, each with a name.

Reward & connection

Room: anywhere that isn't the office — no agenda item allowed. **Exhale:** the whole day is one, deliberately.

1. One shared experience the whole group does together, no rotations
2. Recognition — specific, said out loud, not a slide
3. Unstructured time — the least scheduled block wins

Worked when: people talk about it, unprompted, a year later.

The venue & logistics checklist.

Walk this before you sign anything. The items people miss are almost always A/V, breakout space and accessibility — expensive to fix on the day.

SPACE

- ☐ Main room fits the group in the layout you want
- ☐ A breakout space or two
- ☐ Natural light — a room you won't hate by 3pm
- ☐ Quiet space for a call or a breather
- ☐ A kitchen or prep space you're allowed to use
- ☐ Outdoor space within a two-minute walk

A/V & POWER

- ☐ Screen, projector/TV, HDMI + adapters
- ☐ Mics for any room over ~25 people
- ☐ Reliable Wi-Fi and enough outlets
- ☐ Someone who can fix it fast if it fails

FOOD & COMFORT

- ☐ Meals + breaks ordered; dietary needs covered
- ☐ Coffee that doesn't run out
- ☐ Rooming list, if it's overnight
- ☐ Water in the room, all day
- ☐ Somewhere to eat that isn't the working room
- ☐ Permission to bring your own food in

PEOPLE & ACCESS

- ☐ Travel, directions and parking sent
- ☐ Accessibility needs asked about — and met
- ☐ Materials, name tents, printouts
- ☐ A named point person on the day

ONE MORE THING

Ask the venue what else is booked that day. A wedding setup in the next ballroom has ruined more debriefs than bad Wi-Fi.

Prep timeline & budget worksheet.

6 weeks out	Sponsor alignment (page 4), dates locked, venue held, provider briefed
4 weeks out	Agenda drafted, invites out, travel + rooming, F&B ordered
2 weeks out	Final headcount, run-of-show, pre-reads sent, A/V confirmed
Week of	Print materials, brief facilitators, send the logistics email
After	Send commitments + photos within 48 hours; schedule the 30-day check-in

BUDGET WORKSHEET

LINE ITEM	EST.	ACTUAL
Venue / meeting space		
Food & beverage		
A/V & production		
Facilitation / team experience		
Travel & lodging		
Materials & misc.		
Contingency (~10%)		
Total		

Rooms and food are table stakes — nobody remembers either. The line that decides whether the offsite gets talked about next year is facilitation. If something has to give, give somewhere else.

The 30 days after decide whether it was worth it.

Most offsites die on the flight home. Three moves keep the commitments alive — none takes more than fifteen minutes.

WITHIN 48 HOURS

Send the commitments exactly as people said them — names, owners, dates — plus the photos.

WEEK 2

One prompt to each person: what's one thing you've done differently since?

DAY 30

A 30-minute check-in: what held, what slipped, what we're changing. Calendar it before you leave.

We'll bring the experience that makes it land.

You've got the plan handled. The piece that turns a good agenda into an offsite people talk about for years is the shared experience in the middle — and that's exactly what we do. We come to your venue, anywhere in the country.

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